

SUVASHIS MULLICK



KOLKATA | Landing in Trouble

The vexed issue of land continues to haunt the West Bengal Government. After the high-profile Nandigram and Singur projects, two other showcase initiatives are in limbo. The Alipore Zoo, cramped in the Kolkata heartland, is in urgent need of relocation. Land has been earmarked on the outskirts of the city but rather than start work there, the Government is dragging its feet. Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's

prestigious project, Alia University, has also run into rough weather. In Nano-echoes, farmers are refusing to part with their lands designated for the university. Forty of the 70 acres of land slotted for the university is held by farmers. The issue has become a punching bag for Bhattacharya and his bete noire, Land Reforms Minister Rezzak Mollah, who is fighting the farmland acquisition tooth and nail.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

AHMEDABAD | Untying the Knot

The marriage between 23-year-old Hindu boy Urmil Shah and Karishma Agha, a Muslim girl, has divided the local Sangh Parivar at Khambhat in central Gujarat. Shah converted to Islam to marry Agha and the marriage was blessed by BJP MLA Shirish Shukla, a friend of the girl's uncle. Shukla denies the 'charge' but has not publicly opposed Shah's changing his religion, which has also managed to infringe Gujarat's anti-conversion law. The law says that the convert and the priest carrying out the conversion must inform the district collector in advance. Failure to do so invites imprisonment up to one year for the priest and seven years for the convert. Given that neither Shah nor the Muslim cleric did this, they face legal action and the local administration the dilemma of how to untangle this knot.

AGHA (LEFT) AND SHAH



DELHI | The Big Dogfight

In the world's biggest arms contract, the IAF begins trials of the contenders for the 126 multi-role fighter planes it seeks

	Strength	Weakness		Strength	Weakness
F-16 SUPER VIPER (US)	The F-16 is one of the most successful fighters of all time.	Pakistan Air Force has a large number; it is their main strike aircraft.	MIG-35 (RUSSIA)	Low cost, product support exists because IAF has been operating it.	Outclassed by Western aircraft. IAF doesn't want more Russian machines.
F/A-18 SUPER HORNET (US)	Equipped with a revolutionary phased array radar that has a range of over 100 km.	Vulnerable to political pressure and possible sanctions since it is a US system.	GRIPEN (SWEDEN)	A low cost light multi-role fighter, it is what the IAF originally wanted.	Gripen has been outclassed by twin-engined aircraft vying for the lucrative contract.
RAFALE (FRANCE)	It is one of the most advanced fourth generation fighters in the world.	Rafale also happens to be the costliest fighter aircraft in the fray.	EUROFIGHTER TYPHOON (EU)	A strong contender and an independent alternative to the US system.	It is expensive, which means creating a new and pricey logistics chain.
TOTAL CONTRACT: OVER \$10 BN		TRIALS BEGIN: AUGUST 2009	TRIALS END: APRIL 2010	CONTRACT TO BE FINALISED BY: MARCH 2011	

by Sandeep Unnithan